ENGLISH C1 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Notional agreement

Choose agreement according to grammatical form, collective meaning, proximity and quantity interpretation in complex subjects. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use notional agreement to match the verb and pronoun to whether the subject is viewed as one unit, several members or one quantity while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Choose agreement according to grammatical form, collective meaning, proximity and quantity interpretation in complex subjects.

MODEL

The committee has reached its decision, but the members remain divided.

grammatical head + notional number + variety convention

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main notional agreement patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses match the verb and pronoun to whether the subject is viewed as one unit, several members or one quantity.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in formal writing, reporting and edited general english.

Build meaning before form

Choose agreement according to grammatical form, collective meaning, proximity and quantity interpretation in complex subjects.

What notional agreement communicates

Choose agreement according to grammatical form, collective meaning, proximity and quantity interpretation in complex subjects.

The central purpose is to match the verb and pronoun to whether the subject is viewed as one unit, several members or one quantity. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The committee has reached its decision.	a group presented as one institutional unit
The committee are divided in their opinions.	individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement
Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.	a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: grammatical head + notional number + variety convention. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The committee has reached its decision, but the members remain divided.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Collective unit	collective noun + singular verb/pronoun	The committee has reached its decision.
Collective members	collective noun + plural verb/pronoun	The committee are divided in their opinions.
Quantity as unit	measure/amount + singular verb	Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a group presented as one institutional unit	Collective unit
individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement	Collective members
a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount	Quantity as unit

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in formal writing, reporting and edited general english. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
grammatical head	notional number	variety convention

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: match the verb and pronoun to whether the subject is viewed as one unit, several members or one quantity.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits formal writing, reporting and edited general english.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Collective unit	collective noun + singular verb/pronoun	The committee has reached its decision.
Collective members	collective noun + plural verb/pronoun	The committee are divided in their opinions.
Quantity as unit	measure/amount + singular verb	Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The committee has reached its decision.	a group presented as one institutional unit
The committee are divided in their opinions.	individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement
Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.	a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not switch between singular and plural reference without a meaning change.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Check the target variety because collective agreement differs across Englishes.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not choose agreement solely from the nearest plural noun.

01 · PRACTICE STAGE

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a group presented as one institutional unit?

OPTIONS The committee has reached its decision. · The committee are divided in their opinions. · Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement?

OPTIONS The committee are divided in their opinions. · Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat. · The committee has reached its decision.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount?

OPTIONS Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat. · The committee has reached its decision. · The committee are divided in their opinions.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The committee has reached its decision.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a group presented as one institutional unit · individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement · a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The committee are divided in their opinions.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement · a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount · a group presented as one institutional unit

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount · a group presented as one institutional unit · individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The committee has reached its decision." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Collective unit / Collective members / Quantity as unit · Gap 2: a group presented as one institutional unit / individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement / a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The committee are divided in their opinions." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Collective members / Quantity as unit / Collective unit · Gap 2: individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement / a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount / a group presented as one institutional unit

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Quantity as unit / Collective unit / Collective members · Gap 2: a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount / a group presented as one institutional unit / individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a group presented as one institutional unit: _____. Choose the model that expresses individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement: _____. Choose the model that expresses a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount: _____. Choose the model built with collective noun + singular verb/pronoun: _____. Choose the model built with collective noun + plural verb/pronoun: _____. Choose the model built with measure/amount + singular verb: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat. · The committee are divided in their opinions. · The committee has reached its decision.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The _____ its decision. The _____ in their opinions. _____ too far to walk in this heat. State the full structural pattern for Collective unit: _____. State the full structural pattern for Collective members: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The committee acted as a single body.” using the Collective unit pattern to express a group presented as one institutional unit.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The members of the committee disagree.” using the Collective members pattern to express individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “The distance of ten kilometres is excessive.” using the Quantity as unit pattern to express a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The committee acted as a single body.” using the Collective unit pattern to express a group presented as one institutional unit.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Collective unit to express a group presented as one institutional unit, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Collective members to express individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Quantity as unit to express a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The committee has reached its decision.

Collective unit is the best match because a group presented as one institutional unit.

A2

The committee are divided in their opinions.

Collective members is the best match because individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement.

A3

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

Quantity as unit is the best match because a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount.

A4

a group presented as one institutional unit

The Collective unit pattern communicates a group presented as one institutional unit.

A5

individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement

The Collective members pattern communicates individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement.

A6

a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

The Quantity as unit pattern communicates a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Collective unit / a group presented as one institutional unit

The structure belongs to the Collective unit pattern. Its communicative purpose is a group presented as one institutional unit.

B2

Collective members / individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement

The structure belongs to the Collective members pattern. Its communicative purpose is individual members presented as separate actors in varieties allowing plural agreement.

B3

Quantity as unit / a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount

The structure belongs to the Quantity as unit pattern. Its communicative purpose is a plural-form measure interpreted as one amount.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The committee has reached its decision.

Collective unit: collective noun + singular verb/pronoun.

C2

The committee are divided in their opinions.

Collective members: collective noun + plural verb/pronoun.

C3

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

Quantity as unit: measure/amount + singular verb.

C4

The committee has reached its decision.

Collective unit: collective noun + singular verb/pronoun.

C5

The committee are divided in their opinions.

Collective members: collective noun + plural verb/pronoun.

C6

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

Quantity as unit: measure/amount + singular verb.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

committee has reached

Collective unit requires “committee has reached” in this model. collective noun + singular verb/pronoun.

D2

committee are divided

Collective members requires “committee are divided” in this model. collective noun + plural verb/pronoun.

D3

Ten kilometres is

Quantity as unit requires “Ten kilometres is” in this model. measure/amount + singular verb.

D4

collective noun + singular verb/pronoun

Collective unit is built as collective noun + singular verb/pronoun.

D5

collective noun + plural verb/pronoun

Collective members is built as collective noun + plural verb/pronoun.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The committee has reached its decision.

collective noun + singular verb/pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended collective unit effect.

E2

The committee are divided in their opinions.

collective noun + plural verb/pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended collective members effect.

E3

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat.

measure/amount + singular verb. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended quantity as unit effect.

E4

The committee has reached its decision.

collective noun + singular verb/pronoun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended collective unit effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The committee has reached its decision. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses collective noun + singular verb/pronoun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The committee are divided in their opinions. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses collective noun + plural verb/pronoun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

Ten kilometres is too far to walk in this heat. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses measure/amount + singular verb accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____